in 2017—the Patidars and the tribals. The big news from Saurashtra was the saffron party reclaiming close to 55 per cent of the Patidar vote it had lost to the Congress in 2017, says the India Today-Axis My India exit poll. Indeed, it ended with AAP owning a marginally higher share of the Patidar vote than the Congress. The 48 seats in Saurashtra's 11 districts are keenly watched as a cue to larger trends: the BJP made inroads into traditional Congress bastions. In Morbi district, for instance, where the bridge collapse tragedy shocked the state, the BJP won all three seats, earlier held by the Congress.

The saffron sweep of Surat is in keeping with the targets given to two of the strongest state BJP leaders today—home minister Harsh Sanghvi, who scored a hat-trick win from Majura in Surat city, and Navsari MP and state BJP chief C.R. Paatil. AAP had made its poll debut from the Surat Municipal Corporation with 27 seats in 2021—so everyone had expected this to be a vulnerable flank. But the script reversed as even AAP state convenor, the firebrand Gopal Italia, lost from Katargam.

The tribal segment was the other big win for the BJP—it won 24 of the 27 ST reserved seats in Gujarat, an increase of 12 seats compared to the previous election. The party's Mohan Konkani won from Vyara, an ST reserved seat held by the Congress since Independence. Modi started his campaign from the tribal region of Kaprada in south Gujarat; two of the five Gaurav Yatra routes started in Unai, a tribal stronghold that has been at the heart of the Par-Tapi-Narmada river-linking project protests. The party's tactic of acquiring Congress MLAs has worked here. Four of them had been brought over to the BJP by 2022—two of them in the first week of November, after the announcement of elections. Of these, three were fielded by the party; and two won, including Rajendrasinh Rathwa, son of Mohansinh Rathwa, a nine-term Congress MLA from Chhota Udepur.

While it has scored with every community, the BJP seems to be struggling with Dalits and Muslims. The exit polls show the party's share of Dalit votes was down to 22 per cent—a 6 percentage point drop from 2017. Here again, the Congress suffered more, down from 58 per cent to 35 per cent. The missing votes, expectedly, have gone to AAP, which bagged a sizeable 30 per cent of Dalit votes. With the OBCs, exit polls show almost up to 57 per cent voted saffron. That may be two percentage points less than in 2017, but the erosion is way starker for the Congress—which has got only 22 per cent across those 140 communities, down 10 percentage points from last time.

The Congress had bagged 84 per cent of the Muslim vote share in 2017. This is down to around 54 per cent this time, say the polls. The factors are quite similar with this electorate. "Muslim votes mostly belong to the lower income groups, and AAP's promises initially got the attention of Muslim women and youth. Then came the disillusionment with the party's silence over the Bilkis Bano case accused's release and the flogging of youth in Kheda. And many of them reverted to the Congress," says Ahmedabad-based social activist Mujaheed Nafees. The BJP has declined to around 8 per cent of the Muslim vote share, down from 13 per cent in 2017. That said, the saffron party has had success too; it won the Muslim-majority Dariapur seat in Ahmedabad for the first time where women are believed to have voted for the BJP in large numbers.

Modi's popularity continues in the 18-35 age bracket with 45 per cent saying aye (against 46 per cent last time). The Congress share has almost halved, down from 45 per cent to 24 per cent, the difference possibly shifting to AAP which has got a thumbs-up from 23 per cent of the youth. Many first-time voters—who have seen no party in power other than the BJP—are clearly not enthused about *parivartan* (change), as was being speculated. The BJP is surprisingly losing out with the senior citizens, dropping in their esteem by 5 percentage points to 48 per cent in 2022. The party still remains a favourite with women, with 48 per cent inking their fingers for it, only a marginal decrease from 51 per cent in 2017, possibly due to the presence of AAP. The Congress's overall decline reflects in the confidence of the womenfolk too, down to 27 per cent from 40 per cent in 2017. AAP made only a marginal dent here—19 per cent and 16 per cent housewives vis-a-vis 47 per cent of the latter for the BJP—but enough to subvert old patterns. Overall, the mandate coming out of Gujarat is not just for the 15th legislative assembly. It's a referendum for Modi and 2024. The BJP has significantly consolidated community-wise vote banks, but the emergence of AAP with 4.1 million votes and 13 per cent of the vote could become the big story in years to come. ■

HOW GUJARAT VOTED

The India Today-Axis My India exit poll shows the BJP held its own and even gained vote share except among Muslims and Dalits

